

## IN CONTEXT

### Austria's wars

For much of the period between 1792 and 1815, Austria and its allies were at war with France, which had become a dynamic power as a result of the French Revolution of 1789. The Austrian emperors maintained traditional hierarchical authority against revolutionary egalitarianism. While Beethoven was in Vienna, the city was twice occupied by the French troops of Emperor Napoleon, in 1805 and 1809. The French were defeated in 1814–1815 and Austria assumed a dominant role in Europe.



NAPOLEON AT THE BATTLE OF AUSTERLITZ,  
FRANÇOIS GERARD, 1805

## Deafness and isolation

It is a bitter irony that during this period of supreme musical achievement, Beethoven was losing his hearing. The medical reason for this is unknown. As early as 1802, he wrote that he was avoiding company because people might notice his deafness and that he felt “driven to despair.” A series of quack treatments failed to alleviate his